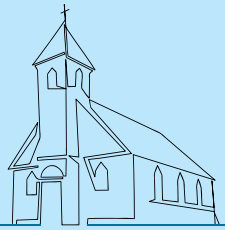
Tamil Nadu
where stories never end



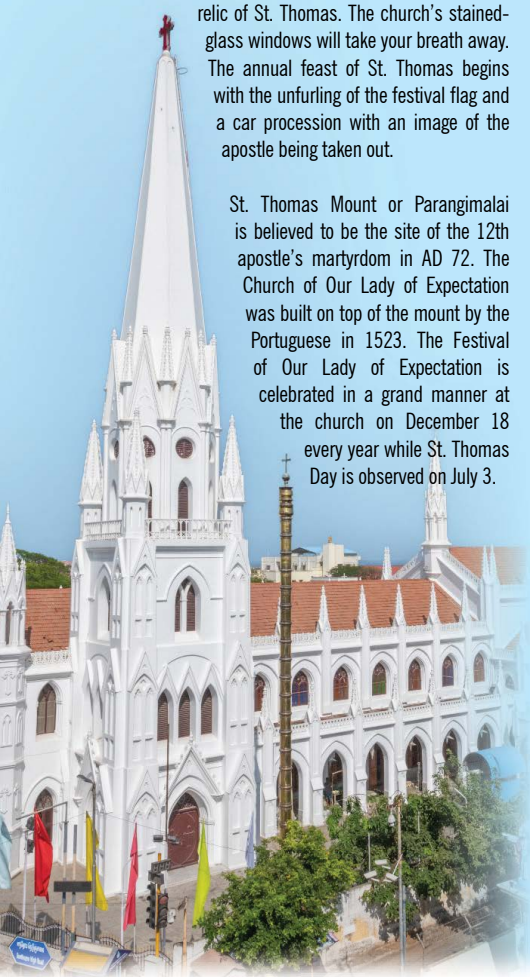
# Taking the Church Trail in Tamil Nadu

The churches of Tamil Nadu will wow you with their architecture, rich history and mesmerising festivities. Christianity has deep roots in the region, dating back to the 1st century AD, when St. Thomas, one of the 12 apostles of Christ, arrived to establish Christianity. Over the centuries, many churches have been built in Tamil Nadu, including those by the Portuguese, Danes and British.

## CHENNAI

San Thome Church, also known as St. Thomas Cathedral Basilica in Chennai is built over the tomb of St. Thomas. Although St. Thomas's mortal remains were removed to Italy, a cross on the tomb's wall contains a relic of St. Thomas. The church's stained-glass windows will take your breath away. The annual feast of St. Thomas begins with the unfurling of the festival flag and a car procession with an image of the apostle being taken out.

St. Thomas Mount or Parangimalai is believed to be the site of the 12th apostle's martyrdom in AD 72. The Church of Our Lady of Expectation was built on top of the mount by the Portuguese in 1523. The Festival of Our Lady of Expectation is celebrated in a grand manner at the church on December 18 every year while St. Thomas Day is observed on July 3.



Situated within Fort St. George, St Mary's Church is an Anglican church, considered as the oldest British structure in India in India. Its impressive spire was added later. Other churches you can visit in Chennai to experience its unique cultural tapestry, history, and architecture include Descanco Church, Our Lady of Light Church (aka Luz Church), and the Armenian Church.

## VELANKANNI

The Basilica of Our Lady of Good Health, situated in Velankanni, is a shrine in the Gothic architectural style devoted to the Virgin Mary. An annual 10-day festival at the shrine culminates in the Feast of Our Lady of Good Health on September 8. The basilica is lit up with multi-coloured fairy lights at night. Visitors of all faiths flock to the shrine throughout the year. The Museum of Offerings is a must-visit.

## THARANGAMBADI

Built in 1718 by the Danish missionary Bartholomaeus Ziegenbalg, the cross-shaped New Jerusalem Church is in the Danish architectural style with some Indian elements during Christmas, with a array of multi-coloured lights.

## MANAPAD

The 16th-century Holy Cross Church in Manapad was built after a storm-struck Portuguese ship found safe haven here. The church is noted for its intricate murals and exquisite altarpiece. The annual Feast of the Exaltation of the Holy Cross, held on September 14, celebrates the recovery of the True Cross by the Byzantine Emperor Heraclius from the Persians.

## THOOTHUKUDI

The 16th-century Basilica of Our Lady of Snows (aka Paniya Matha Church) is one of the notable pilgrim sites of Tamil Nadu, built in the Portuguese style. The Basilica's Golden Car Festival sees thousands of attendance every year.

## UVARI

Kappal Matha Church in the seaside village of Uvari in Tirunelveli district is unique in being shaped like an airplane atop on a ship. The church was built in 1974 after the original church was damaged due to sea erosion.

## KONANKUPPAM

The Periyanayagi Madha Shrine or the Shrine of Our Lady of Periyanayagi is located in Konankuppam, Cuddalore District. The historic Roman Catholic church dedicated to St. Mary was built by an Italian missionary, Fr. Constantine Joseph Beschi. The church looks beautiful with its exterior painted white with blue borders. An annual festival at the shrine commemorating St.Mary, occurs from January 14 to 23, with a procession led by a decorated car.

These, along with numerous other exquisite churches, form Tamil Nadu's church trail.







